

V OF IV IN THE BLUES

FROM DIGGING DEEPER JAZZ VIDEO #16

In the blues, we would typically talk about the harmony of the 1st four measures as being "I - IV - I - I". But, we can also think of it as "I - IV - I - V/IV". The idea that the fourth measure can be thought of as a V chord preceding a key change to the key of IV (in this instance, a C7 chord resolving to the new key of F7 in the fifth measure).

13 C7 F7 C7 C7

5 F7 F7 C7 C7

9 Dm7 G7 C7 G7

this measure can be thought of two different ways

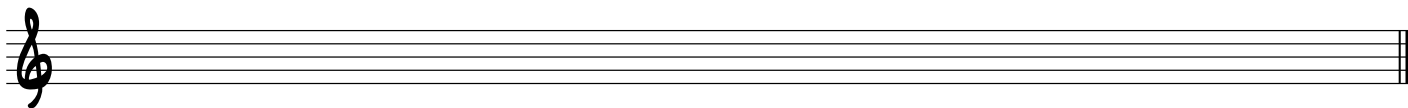
Below is an example of how to make that fourth measure sound like a V/IV. We are making that C7 in the fourth measure sound "more dissonant" or "more tense" or "more dominant" by altering it a bit. In this instance, we are altering it by playing it as an augmented triad. The device we use in that measure doesn't really matter. It could be almost any kind of tension. The point is that we create some tension in that spot that resolves to the fifth measure F7.

An important corollary is to notice that the material we played in the first three measures was quite SIMPLE (ie. consonant). This helped us REALLY draw attention to the tension in the fourth measure, and to make that moment even more dramatic. One way to make something even more tense is to precede it by something LESS tense.

13 C7 F7 C7 C7

17 F7 F7 C7 C7

21 Dm7 G7 C7 G7



Bessies Blues

Of the 4,215,679 different recordings of the blues (yes, I've counted them all), this is one of the most instructive recordings, especially regards one particular harmonic device - the V/IV (pronounced "five of four") in the fourth measure. Listen to Coltrane's short 5 or 6 solo (beginning at 1:35). You can really hear when he is playing a consonant, "I chord/tonic chord" type idea in the 4th measure of every chorus, and then when he is playing tenser, more dissonant "V/IV" material.

Most of those spots (the 4th measure of every chorus) are pretty easy to hear what Coltrane is doing on this recording, one way or the other. I don't mean hearing exactly the notes he is playing, but EMOTIONALLY hearing what he is doing. Just ask yourself - does it sound "in" or does it sound "out"? Does it sound "tense" or sound "relaxed"? Just listen with that kind of simplistic "either/or" kind of hearing. You might be surprised how well you get a sense of what he is doing.

Bessie's Blues (from the Crescent album) - <https://youtu.be/XMC2bvHk0Bo>

HOW TO PRACTICE THIS

Practice this exact thing! Play 20 choruses of blues every day for the next two weeks, and use whatever device you want in that fourth measure. I've attached a sheet that uses an augmented triad. It doesn't really matter WHAT device you use. It could be a tritone substitute, the altered scale, a cool Freddie Hubbard lick, volume, density, a polyrhythm . . . anything that adds tension or creates direction.

FOR DRUMMERS

This applies to drums too (a cool Bill Stewart lick, volume, density, a polyrhythm . . .). Pick places in the music where you EMOTIONALLY hear tension. We melodic/harmonic guys are choosing the 4th measure of the blues due to the harmonic motion there. You don't HAVE to do it in that exact spot (like we melodic guys do), but I'd suggest having a predetermined place in the blues to aim for, and then practice your device MANY times over in that same exact spot.

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